

New Hanover County Economic Profile

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Executive Summary

Performance Category: Moderate Growth

County Size: Major Metro (100k+)

Region: Coastal

New Hanover County showed moderate economic expansion from Q3 2024 to Q3 2025, with employment growth of 1.69%, wage growth of 6.07%, and establishment growth of 3.08%. These metrics all exceed the statewide average.

Sector Highlights: Growth was led by **Education & Health Services** (+1,855 jobs, +7.69%) and **Financial Activities** (+348 jobs, +5.05%). **Professional & Business Services** added 392 jobs (+2.13%) and **Leisure & Hospitality** added 201 (+0.98%). Offsetting these gains, **Construction** shed 396 jobs (-4.00%) and both **Federal** (-5) and **Local Government** (-57) contracted modestly. Data suppression prevents reporting for Natural Resources & Mining, Manufacturing, and Information.

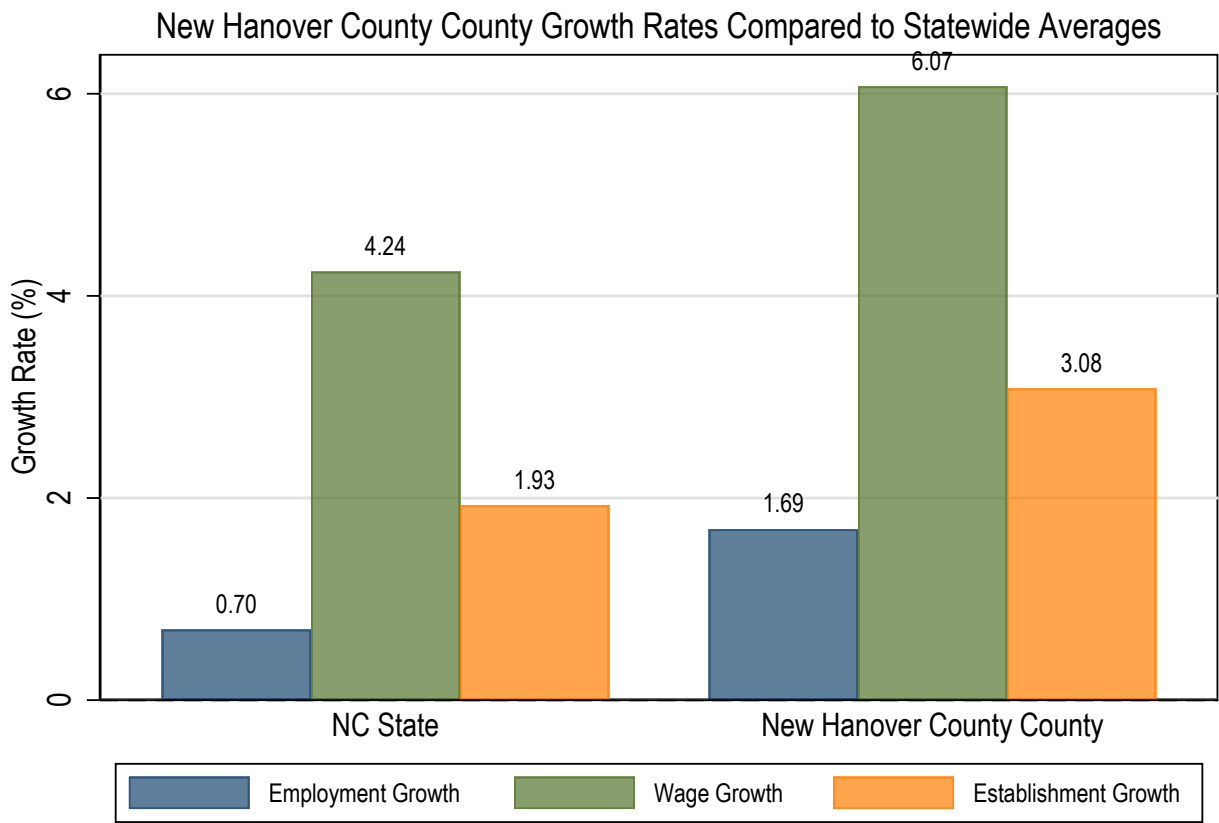
Key Economic Indicators

Metric	Q3 2024	Q3 2025	Change	% Change
Employment				
Total Employment	130,249	132,452	2,203	1.69%
<i>vs NC State</i>				+0.99 pp
Wages				
Avg Weekly Wage	\$1,169.00	\$1,240.00	\$71.00	6.07%
<i>vs NC State</i>				+1.83 pp
Avg Annual Wage	\$60,799	\$64,497	\$3,698	6.08%
Establishments				
Total Establishments	11,284	11,632	348	3.08%
<i>vs NC State</i>				+1.15 pp
Employees per Establishment	11.54	11.39	-0.16	-1.35%
Total Wage Bill				
Total Quarterly Wages	\$1,979,743,256	\$2,135,675,230	\$155,931,968	7.88%

Table 1: New Hanover County economic performance metrics, Q3 2024 vs Q3 2025

How does New Hanover County compare?

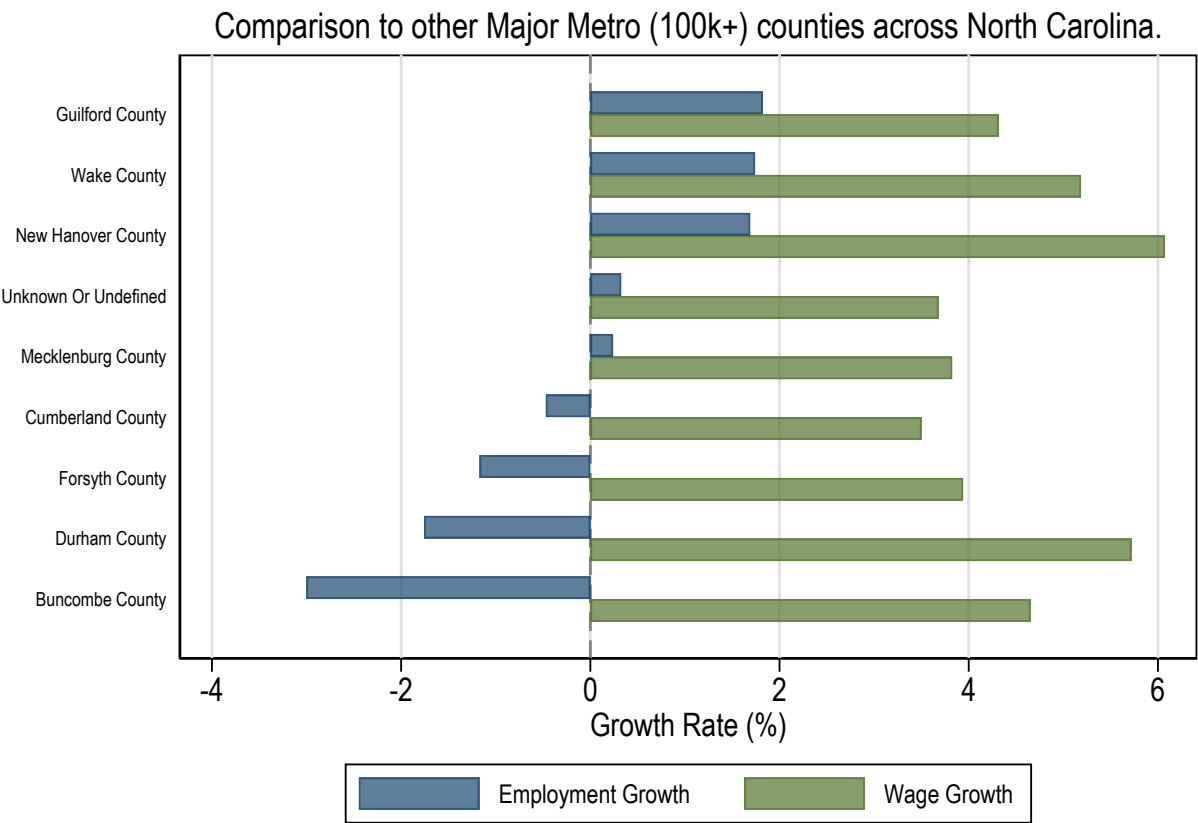
Comparison to North Carolina State Average



Source: BLS QCEW Data, Q3 2024 vs Q3 2025

Figure 1: New Hanover County growth rates compared to statewide averages.

Similar-Sized County Comparison



Source: BLS QCEW Data, Q3 2024 vs Q3 2025

Figure 2: Comparison to other Major Metro (100k+) counties across North Carolina.

Statewide Positioning

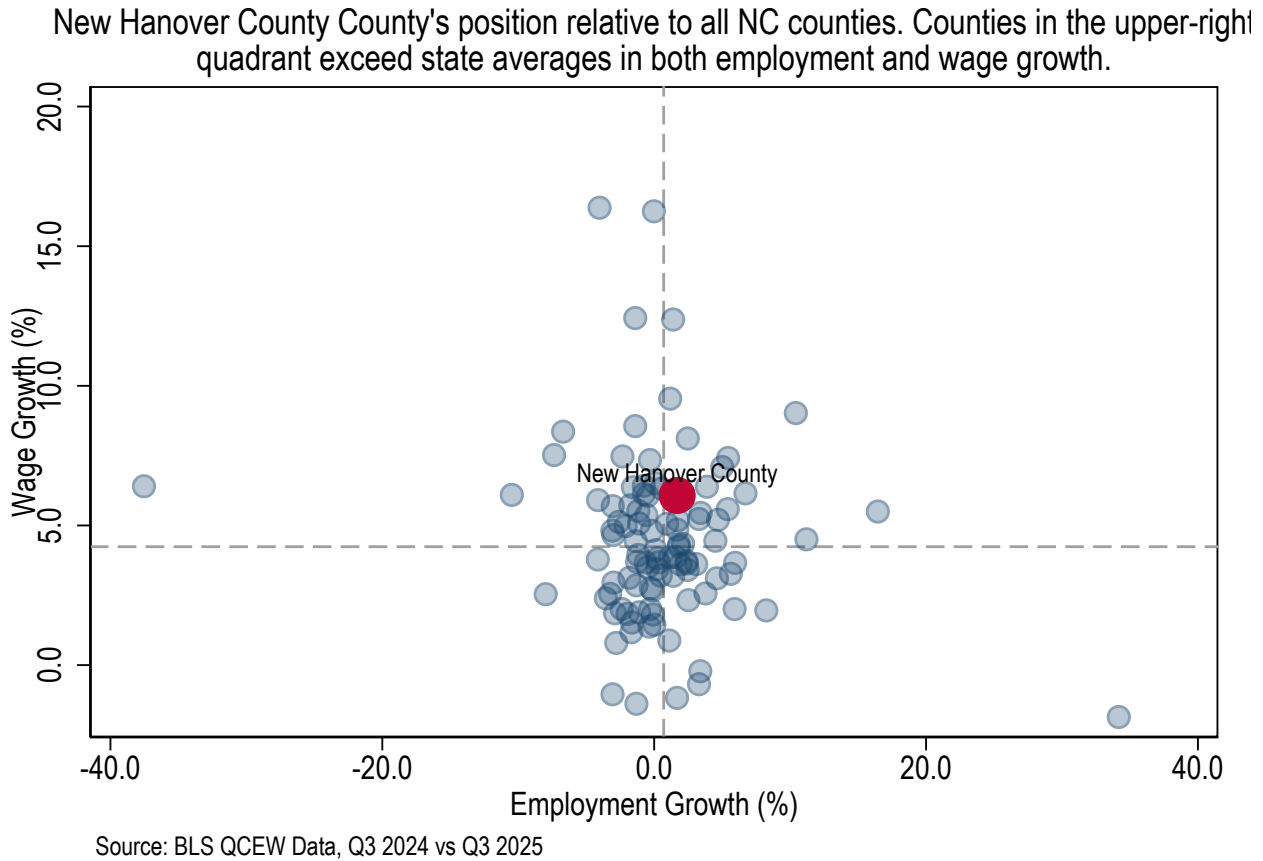


Figure 3: New Hanover County vs all NC counties. Upper-right quadrant = above-average employment AND wage growth.

Employment by Sector: Q3 2024 vs Q3 2025

The table below shows employment levels, absolute change, and percentage change for each major sector in New Hanover County. Government rows cover Federal, State, and Local government employment. Private rows cover major NAICS supersectors.

Sector	2024 Emp	2025 Emp	Change	% Chg	2025 Avg Weekly Wage	Wage % Chg
Government						
Federal Government	1,139	1,134	-5	-0.41%	\$1,980	5.54%
State Government	5,207	5,340	134	2.57%	\$1,281	0.39%
Local Government	6,856	6,799	-57	-0.84%	\$1,312	4.63%
Private Sector						
Natural Resources & Mining	153	—	—	—	—	—
Construction	9,920	9,524	-396	-4.00%	\$1,403	7.35%
Manufacturing	6,131	—	—	—	—	—
Trade, Transportation & Utilities	23,752	23,825	72	0.30%	\$1,009	4.24%
Information	2,450	—	—	—	—	—
Financial Activities	6,878	7,226	348	5.05%	\$1,732	5.22%
Professional & Business Services	18,375	18,767	392	2.13%	\$1,587	7.09%
Education & Health Services	24,133	25,987	1,855	7.69%	\$1,367	6.63%
Leisure & Hospitality	20,588	20,789	201	0.98%	\$535	5.73%
Other Services	4,667	4,791	124	2.65%	\$840	3.07%

Table 2: New Hanover County employment by sector, Q3 2024 vs Q3 2025. Source: BLS QCEW. Employment is average monthly employment for the quarter. Wage is average weekly wage. Suppressed BLS cells appear as missing values.

Why does this matter?

Key Findings

- **Steady Employment Growth:** New Hanover County's 1.69% employment growth exceeded the state average of 0.70%, placing it in the Moderate Growth category with a +0.99 pp difference.
- **Wage Performance:** Average weekly wages increased by 6.07%, exceeding state wage growth by +1.83 pp, indicating quality job creation.
- **Business Formation:** With 3.08% establishment growth significantly exceeding the state average of 1.93%, New Hanover County demonstrated robust business formation, adding 348 new establishments in just one year.
- **Tax Base Impact:** The total quarterly wage bill increased by 7.88% (\$155.9 million), suggesting strong growth in the local tax base.
- **Business Size Trend:** Stable employees per establishment (11.54 to 11.39) suggests balanced growth between new business formation and existing business expansion.

Context

New Hanover County's performance is competitive within its peer group, showing steady progress across key economic indicators. The county maintains stable employment and business growth, positioning it for continued development.

Bottom Line: New Hanover County demonstrates steady economic performance with growth rates generally exceeding state averages across key indicators.